

The Internet is huge and it's getting bigger

You cannot imagine the amount of information on the internet. This is not a statement of exaggeration, nor is it artistic licence taken for literary purposes of shock and surprise. It is quite literally, humanly impossible to actually visualise numbers as big as the amount of information on the internet because we suffer from a cognitive bias called scope insensitivity. While it's easy to rattle off stats about the internet -- in particular, ones that involve absurdly huge, imaginary books it would fill, or the horrific number of imaginary trees those imaginary books would need -- it's far more mind-boggling to get realistic idea of the numbers in context.

There are over a billion websites on the internet, the mark having been reached in 2014. Sure, simple, right? Wrong. Your own single personal computer most likely has several gigabytes of information on it. That's several million kilobytes of information -- several million plain text files, say. Now imagine the number of personal computers in the world. Add the number of personal devices like smartphones and smartwatches. Add the number of commercial computers that keep our trains running, our power systems backed up, our ships and planes on course all day every day. Add the number of household devices connected to the Internet of Things. Add metadata that keeps track of all of these devices.

Are you growing uneasy yet?

Now imagine having to search through each and every single one of those text files, remembering what each of them contains, making difficult and